INTRODUCTION TO POLITICAL SCIENCE

Exam-Oriented Notes for Undergraduate / Diploma Students

Approximate length: 40+ study pages when printed on A4 with standard margins.

How to use these notes: Read the learning points first, memorise key definitions, then practise the questions at the end of each chapter. For essay questions, use the structure: Introduction → Definitions → Main points with explanation → Examples → Conclusion.

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1. Introduction to Political Science

Political science is the systematic study of politics, political institutions, political behaviour, power, government and public policy. It examines how collective decisions are made, how political authority is organised, how resources and values are distributed, and how citizens interact with institutions. Politics can be understood as the process through which societies manage disagreement and allocate scarce resources.

Key points

- Meaning of politics: Politics concerns collective decision-making, conflict, cooperation and the distribution of resources and values.
- Meaning of political science: A systematic and organised study of political phenomena using empirical, comparative, historical and normative approaches.
- Nature of the discipline: It is both empirical and normative. Empirical political science asks what is happening and why; normative political thought asks what ought to happen.
- Politics, government and the state are related but distinct. Politics is the process; government is the machinery for making and implementing decisions; the state is the enduring political organisation with territory, population, government and sovereignty.
- Why study political science? It develops civic understanding, analytical skills, awareness of institutions, ability to evaluate public policy and capacity to understand political conflict and cooperation.

Exam-oriented questions

- Define political science and explain its importance.
- Differentiate between politics and political science.
- Explain the relationship between politics, government and the state.
- Discuss the empirical and normative dimensions of political science.

Quick revision box

Remember: In an exam, definitions should be precise and followed by explanation. Avoid listing points without explaining how or why they matter. Where possible, connect concepts to institutions, elections, public policy, governance and contemporary political life.

2. Scope, Nature and Approaches

The scope of political science is broad. Introductory courses commonly cover political theory, comparative politics, public administration, international relations, public policy, political institutions, political behaviour and research methods. University course outlines in Kenya also emphasise the state, government, political systems, constitutions, elections, representation, governance, power, ideology, liberty, justice, equality and rights.

Key points

- Political theory: study of political ideas, values and arguments about authority, justice, freedom and the good society.
- Comparative politics: comparison of political systems, institutions, regimes and political behaviour across countries.
- International relations: study of relations among states and other international actors.
- Public administration: study of implementation of government decisions and management of public institutions.
- Public policy: analysis of government decisions intended to influence behaviour or address public problems.
- Political behaviour: study of voting, participation, public opinion, political attitudes and group behaviour.
- Historical approach: uses political history to explain institutions and political development.
- Institutional approach: focuses on formal institutions such as legislatures, executives and courts.
- Behavioural approach: emphasises observable political behaviour and systematic evidence.
- Systems approach: views politics as a system of inputs, decision processes, outputs and feedback.

Exam-oriented questions

- Explain five major approaches to the study of politics.
- Discuss the scope of political science.
- Distinguish between normative and empirical political analysis.

3. Politics, Power, Authority and Legitimacy

Power is central to political science. It concerns the capacity of an actor to influence behaviour or outcomes. Authority is power regarded as legitimate or rightful. Legitimacy refers to the belief that an institution or ruler has a valid right to exercise political authority. These concepts help explain why people obey laws, how governments make decisions and why some political orders are stable while others face resistance.

Key points

- Power may be coercive, economic, ideological, institutional or based on persuasion.
- Authority may be traditional, charismatic or legal-rational in Weberian analysis.
- Legitimacy can come from constitutional rules, elections, tradition, performance, consent or widely accepted political values.
- Influence is the ability to affect another actor without necessarily possessing formal authority.
- Coercion relies on threats or force; persuasion attempts to change preferences through argument or communication.
- Power may be visible in formal decisions, agenda-setting and the shaping of beliefs or preferences.
- Political accountability limits arbitrary use of power by requiring office holders to explain and justify decisions.

Exam-oriented questions

- Differentiate power, authority and legitimacy.
- Explain sources of political power.
- Discuss the importance of legitimacy in governance.
- Explain three forms of authority.

Quick revision box

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4. The State and Its Elements

The state is a central concept in political science. A state is a political organisation exercising authority over a defined territory and population. Introductory political science identifies four core elements: population, territory, government and sovereignty. The state should not be confused with the government, which is the set of institutions and office holders currently exercising public authority.

Key points

- Population: a permanent community of people subject to the authority of the state.
- Territory: a defined geographical area over which state authority is exercised.
- Government: institutions through which public decisions are made and enforced.
- Sovereignty: supreme political authority within the territory and independence in external affairs.
- The state is relatively permanent; governments can change through elections, succession, resignation or other constitutional processes.
- A nation refers primarily to a community connected by shared history, identity, culture or political aspirations; a nation-state combines national identity with a sovereign state.
- Functions of the state include maintaining security, providing public services, regulating economic activity, protecting rights, collecting revenue and representing the country internationally.

Exam-oriented questions

- Discuss the four elements of the state.
- Differentiate between state and government.
- Differentiate between state, nation and nation-state.
- Explain the functions of the modern state.

Quick revision box

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5. Theories of the Origin of the State

Political thinkers have proposed different explanations for the emergence of states. These theories are useful for understanding political authority, although modern states generally developed through multiple historical processes rather than a single universal cause.

Key points

- Divine theory: historically associated political authority with divine will or religious sanction.
- Force theory: argues that some states emerged through conquest and domination of one group by another.
- Social contract theory: associated with thinkers such as Hobbes, Locke and Rousseau; it explains political authority through an agreement, actual or hypothetical, among people.
- Evolutionary theory: sees the state as developing gradually from families, clans, tribes and increasingly complex forms of social organisation.
- Economic or material explanations emphasise property, production, inequality, conflict and the need to regulate resources.
- Modern explanations combine geography, warfare, economic organisation, administrative capacity, identity and historical institutions.

Exam-oriented questions

- Explain the social contract theory of the origin of the state.
- Discuss the force theory.
- Compare divine, force, evolutionary and social contract explanations.

6. Sovereignty

Sovereignty refers to supreme authority. Internally, it means the state has final authority over persons and institutions within its jurisdiction. Externally, it refers to independence from the authority of other states. Sovereignty remains important in international relations, although modern states accept treaties, international law and regional obligations.

Key points

- Internal sovereignty: supreme authority within the state.
- External sovereignty: independence and legal equality in international relations.
- Popular sovereignty: the ultimate political authority is located in the people.
- Legal sovereignty: identifies the institution legally authorised to make final decisions.
- De jure sovereignty: legally recognised authority; de facto sovereignty: actual control in practice.
- Limitations arise through constitutions, human rights commitments, international treaties, regional organisations and domestic institutions.
- In democratic systems, sovereignty is commonly linked to popular consent and constitutional government.

Exam-oriented questions

- Define sovereignty.
- Explain internal and external sovereignty.
- Discuss the relevance of sovereignty in the modern international system.

7. Government and Systems of Government

Government refers to the institutions and processes through which collective decisions are made and implemented. Governments make laws, enforce rules, provide services, collect revenue, protect security and represent the state. Forms of government can be classified in several ways.

Key points

- Presidential government: executive authority is centred in a president who is normally elected separately from the legislature.
- Parliamentary government: the executive depends on the confidence of parliament and is commonly led by a prime minister.
- Semi-presidential systems combine a directly elected president with a prime minister and cabinet.
- Monarchy: headship is held by a monarch; modern monarchies may be constitutional or absolute.
- Republic: public offices are not held as hereditary monarchic offices.
- Unitary government concentrates constitutional authority at the national level, though decentralisation may occur.
- Federal government constitutionally divides powers between national and subnational governments.

Exam-oriented questions

- Differentiate presidential and parliamentary systems.
- Explain unitary and federal government.
- Discuss advantages and disadvantages of presidential government.

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8. Organs of Government and Separation of Powers

Modern constitutional government commonly distributes public authority among legislative, executive and judicial institutions. Separation of powers seeks to prevent excessive concentration of power, while checks and balances allow institutions to restrain one another.

Key points

- Legislature: makes laws, approves public expenditure, represents citizens and exercises oversight.
- Executive: implements laws, formulates policies, administers government and handles many aspects of national security and foreign affairs.
- Judiciary: interprets laws, resolves disputes and may review whether government actions comply with constitutional rules.
- Checks and balances: each branch has mechanisms for limiting the others.
- Rule of law: public officials and citizens are subject to publicly known and fairly applied laws.
- Constitutionalism: government power is limited and organised by constitutional rules.

Exam-oriented questions

- Explain separation of powers.
- Discuss the functions of the legislature.
- Explain checks and balances and their importance.
- What is constitutionalism?

9. Democracy, Authoritarianism and Political Regimes

Democracy is a system in which citizens have meaningful opportunities to choose leaders and participate in political decision-making. Political regimes differ in how leaders are selected, how power is constrained and how political competition is permitted.

Key points

- Direct democracy: citizens participate directly in decisions.
- Representative democracy: citizens elect representatives who make decisions on their behalf.
- Liberal democracy combines elections with constitutional limits, civil liberties, rights and institutional checks.
- Authoritarian regimes restrict political competition and concentrate significant power in a leader or small group.
- Totalitarianism is an extreme form of political control seeking extensive influence over public and private life.
- Democratic principles include political equality, competitive elections, participation, accountability, transparency, majority rule and protection of minorities.
- Challenges to democracy include corruption, political violence, misinformation, exclusion, weak institutions, unequal resources and declining trust.

Exam-oriented questions

- Define democracy.
- Differentiate direct and representative democracy.
- Compare democratic and authoritarian regimes.
- Discuss challenges facing democracy in developing states.

Quick revision box

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10. Constitution and Constitutionalism

A constitution establishes fundamental rules for organising political authority. It may be written or unwritten, rigid or flexible, and usually addresses institutions, powers, rights and procedures for changing the basic legal order.

Key points

- Functions: establishes institutions, allocates powers, protects rights, regulates succession and provides procedures for law-making.
- Constitutionalism means government operates within constitutional limits rather than according to unrestricted personal discretion.
- A rigid constitution requires special procedures for amendment; a flexible constitution can be changed more easily.
- Constitutional supremacy means ordinary laws and government actions must comply with the constitution.
- Judicial review allows courts to assess the legality or constitutionality of government action where the legal system provides for it.
- A good constitutional order requires institutions capable of enforcing constitutional rules.

Exam-oriented questions

- Define constitution and constitutionalism.
- Explain functions of a constitution.
- Differentiate rigid and flexible constitutions.
- Why is constitutionalism important?

11. Political Parties, Pressure Groups and Civil Society

Political parties seek political power, usually through elections, and attempt to influence government policy. Pressure or interest groups generally seek to influence policy without necessarily seeking to form government. Civil society includes voluntary organisations operating between the individual/family and the state.

Key points

- Functions of parties: recruit leaders, aggregate interests, mobilise voters, formulate policies, provide political education and organise government/opposition.
- Party systems may be one-party, two-party or multiparty.
- Pressure groups may use lobbying, petitions, demonstrations, litigation, media campaigns and research.
- Civil society can promote accountability, human rights, civic education and community interests.
- Risks include elite capture, ethnic mobilisation, misinformation, excessive influence of wealthy interests and weak internal democracy.
- Healthy political competition requires rules that allow participation while protecting electoral integrity.

Exam-oriented questions

- Differentiate political parties and pressure groups.
- Explain functions of political parties.
- Discuss the role of civil society in democratic governance.

12. Elections, Representation and Political Participation

Elections provide a mechanism for selecting leaders and authorising political representatives. Political participation includes voting, campaigning, attending meetings, contacting officials, peaceful protest, public debate and community organising.

Key points

- Electoral systems translate votes into seats. Common systems include plurality/majority, proportional representation and mixed systems.
- Representation may be geographic, demographic, ideological or interest-based.
- Free and fair elections require genuine competition, broad participation, credible administration, secrecy of the ballot and lawful dispute resolution.
- Political participation can be conventional, such as voting, or unconventional, such as protest and civil disobedience.
- Barriers to participation include poverty, discrimination, political intimidation, lack of information, disability, distance and distrust.
- Political accountability is strengthened when citizens can monitor representatives and sanction poor performance through lawful mechanisms.

Exam-oriented questions

- Explain the meaning of political participation.
- Discuss functions of elections.
- Explain factors that influence voter behaviour.
- Compare plurality and proportional representation.

13. Political Ideologies

Political ideologies are organised sets of ideas about how society and government should be structured. Ideologies provide frameworks for understanding authority, equality, markets, property, rights and social change.

Key points

- Liberalism: emphasises individual liberty, rights, constitutional government and often limited government.
- Conservatism: emphasises continuity, order, tradition and cautious rather than radical change.
- Socialism: emphasises social and economic equality and greater collective control or regulation of economic resources.
- Communism: in classical theory seeks a classless society and collective ownership of major productive resources.
- Nationalism: emphasises political identity and loyalty associated with a nation.
- Feminism: analyses gender inequality and seeks political, social and economic equality.
- Capitalism: an economic system centred on private ownership and market exchange; it can coexist with different political regimes.
- Environmentalism/green politics emphasises ecological sustainability and the political consequences of environmental degradation.

Exam-oriented questions

- Define political ideology.
- Explain five political ideologies.
- Compare liberalism and socialism.
- Discuss the role of nationalism in state-building.

Quick revision box

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14. Rights, Liberty, Equality and Justice

Rights are claims or entitlements recognised by law, morality or political principles. Liberty concerns freedom from unjustified interference and, in some traditions, the capacity to act meaningfully. Equality concerns equal status, opportunity or treatment, while justice concerns fairness in the distribution of benefits, burdens, rights and opportunities.

Key points

- Civil liberties include freedoms such as expression, association, conscience and movement, subject to lawful limitations.
- Civil and political rights require protection through institutions, laws and remedies.
- Formal equality means treating persons according to the same legal rules; substantive equality may require addressing structural disadvantage.
- Distributive justice concerns allocation of resources and opportunities.
- Procedural justice concerns fair decision-making procedures.
- Rights may conflict, so constitutional systems often use proportionality, lawful limitations and judicial interpretation to balance competing interests.
- Governments have duties to respect, protect and fulfil rights within the applicable legal framework.

Exam-oriented questions

- Differentiate liberty and equality.
- Explain distributive and procedural justice.
- Discuss the importance of human rights in democratic governance.

15. Public Policy and Governance

Public policy consists of government decisions and actions intended to address public problems or influence behaviour. Governance is broader than government: it includes the processes and relationships through which public decisions are made and implemented, involving state and non-state actors.

Key points

- Policy cycle: problem identification, agenda setting, formulation, adoption, implementation, monitoring and evaluation.
- Policy actors include elected officials, civil servants, courts, experts, businesses, civil society, media and citizens.
- Good governance is commonly associated with participation, transparency, accountability, responsiveness, effectiveness and rule of law.
- Policy failure may arise from poor design, inadequate resources, weak implementation, corruption, conflicting interests or unexpected conditions.
- Evidence-based policy uses reliable information to assess alternatives and outcomes.
- Public interest is contested: different groups may disagree about what benefits society as a whole.

Exam-oriented questions

- Define public policy.
- Explain the policy cycle.
- Discuss principles of good governance.
- Identify causes of policy failure.

Quick revision box

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16. Political Culture and Political Socialisation

Political culture refers to shared orientations, values and expectations about politics. Political socialisation is the process through which people acquire political beliefs and orientations.

Key points

- Agents of socialisation include family, school, peers, religion, media, political parties and community organisations.
- Political culture can support or challenge democratic institutions.
- Civic culture involves attitudes that support participation, tolerance and institutional trust.
- Political socialisation changes across the life course and can be affected by major political events.
- Digital media increasingly influences political communication, mobilisation and public opinion.
- Political tolerance is important because democracy requires coexistence among people with different views.

Exam-oriented questions

- Define political culture.
- Explain agents of political socialisation.
- Discuss the role of media in political socialisation.

17. International Relations and Global Politics

International relations examines interactions among states and other actors across borders. Key issues include security, diplomacy, trade, international law, development, conflict, cooperation and global institutions.

Key points

- Realism emphasises power, security and competition among states.
- Liberal approaches emphasise cooperation, institutions, trade and interdependence.
- Constructivist approaches emphasise ideas, identities, norms and shared meanings.
- International organisations facilitate cooperation, negotiation, rule-making and collective action.
- Foreign policy is the set of strategies and decisions through which a state pursues interests abroad.
- Globalisation increases cross-border flows of people, capital, information, goods and ideas.
- International politics involves both cooperation and conflict.

Exam-oriented questions

- Define international relations.
- Compare realism and liberalism.
- Explain the role of international organisations.
- What is foreign policy?

18. Political Conflict, Violence and Conflict Resolution

Conflict is a disagreement over interests, values, identity or resources. Political conflict is not necessarily violent; democratic institutions can channel disagreement into elections, debate, bargaining and lawful adjudication.

Key points

- Causes include inequality, exclusion, competition for resources, identity divisions, weak institutions, historical grievances and struggles for power.
- Conflict management seeks to reduce harmful effects; conflict resolution addresses underlying issues; conflict transformation seeks deeper changes in relationships and structures.
- Negotiation involves direct bargaining between parties.
- Mediation involves a third party assisting communication and agreement without necessarily imposing a decision.
- Peaceful political participation can reduce the need for violent mobilisation.
- Institutions such as courts, legislatures, electoral bodies and independent commissions can provide channels for dispute resolution.

Exam-oriented questions

- Distinguish conflict management, resolution and transformation.
- Explain causes of political conflict.
- Discuss peaceful methods of resolving political conflict.

19. Political Economy, Development and Inequality

Political economy studies the interaction between political institutions and economic processes. Political choices affect taxation, public spending, regulation, property rights, labour markets and distribution of resources.

Key points

- Economic policies are influenced by political interests and institutional arrangements.
- Inequality may be economic, social, regional, gender-based or political.
- Development involves changes in living standards, capabilities, institutions and productive capacity, not only economic growth.
- Public budgeting expresses political priorities because resources are limited.
- Corruption can divert public resources, weaken institutions and reduce trust.
- Inclusive development requires attention to participation, opportunity, public services and accountability.

Exam-oriented questions

- Define political economy.
- Explain the relationship between politics and economic development.
- Discuss political causes and consequences of inequality.
- Explain how budgeting reflects political priorities.

20. Research Methods in Political Science + Exam Revision

Political science uses systematic methods to investigate political questions. Good research identifies a question, defines concepts, collects evidence and draws conclusions that are appropriate to the evidence.

Key points

- Qualitative methods: interviews, focus groups, observation, case studies and document analysis.
- Quantitative methods: surveys, statistical analysis, experiments and numerical datasets.
- Comparative method: compares political cases to identify similarities, differences and possible explanations.
- Historical method: examines political developments over time.
- Key research concepts include variables, hypotheses, sampling, validity, reliability and causation.
- Ethics require informed participation where appropriate, protection of participants, honesty in reporting and responsible use of data.
- Exam strategy: define the key term, identify the main argument, organise points under clear headings, explain each point, use relevant examples, and conclude by directly answering the question.

Exam-oriented questions

- Describe the scientific method in political research.
- Differentiate qualitative and quantitative methods.
- Explain validity and reliability.
- Write an essay on the nature and scope of political science.

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FINAL EXAM REVISION SECTION

High-value definitions

Term	Exam definition
Politics	The process through which collective decisions are made and conflicts over resources and values are managed.
Political science	The systematic study of political phenomena, institutions, behaviour, power and ideas.
State	A political organisation with a population, defined territory, government and sovereignty.
Government	The institutions and processes through which public decisions are made and implemented.
Power	The capacity of an actor to influence behaviour or outcomes.
Authority	Legitimate or recognised power to make and enforce decisions.
Legitimacy	The perceived rightfulness or acceptability of political authority.
Sovereignty	Supreme authority within a territory together with external independence.
Democracy	A system in which citizens have meaningful opportunities to choose leaders and participate in political decision-making.
Constitution	A fundamental set of rules organising political authority and institutions.
Political party	An organised group seeking political influence or government, usually through elections.
Pressure group	An organised group seeking to influence public policy without necessarily seeking to form government.
Public policy	A government decision or course of action intended to influence behaviour or address a public problem.
Governance	Processes and relationships through which public decisions are made and implemented by state and non-state actors.

COMMON EXAM QUESTIONS

- 1. Define political science and discuss its nature and scope.
- 2. Explain the relationship between politics, government and the state.
- 3. Discuss the elements and functions of the state.
- 4. Explain the theories of the origin of the state.
- 5. Define sovereignty and discuss its types.
- 6. Distinguish power, authority, influence and legitimacy.
- 7. Discuss the functions of government.
- 8. Explain separation of powers and checks and balances.
- 9. Compare presidential and parliamentary systems of government.
- 10. Discuss the meaning, principles and challenges of democracy.
- 11. Explain the functions of a constitution and the meaning of constitutionalism.
- 12. Discuss the role of political parties in a democracy.
- 13. Explain the importance of elections and political participation.
- 14. Discuss five political ideologies.
- 15. Explain the relationship between liberty, equality, rights and justice.
- 16. Discuss the role of civil society in democratic governance.
- 17. Explain the policy cycle and the meaning of good governance.
- 18. Discuss causes of political conflict and peaceful methods of resolution.
- 19. Explain the relationship between politics and economic development.
- 20. Discuss qualitative and quantitative methods used in political science.

Suggested essay structure

- Introduction: define the topic and state the direction of your answer.
- Body: use 5–8 clearly labelled points. Each point should contain a claim, explanation and relevant example.
- Critical analysis: where appropriate, mention strengths, limitations, competing views or challenges.
- Conclusion: summarise the argument and directly answer the question.

REFERENCES AND FURTHER READING

These notes are a study guide written from scratch and are not a reproduction of a particular university handout. Core concepts were cross-checked against OpenStax's Introduction to Political Science materials and publicly available Kenyan university course outlines.

Selected online sources

• OpenStax, *Introduction to Political Science*: definitions and introductory chapters on politics, power, government, the state, empirical and normative political science. https://openstax.org/books/introduction-political-science/

• University of Nairobi course-outline material for introductory/basic concepts in political science: state, government, political system, constitution, elections, representation, governance, power, ideology, liberty, justice, equality and rights.

• Mount Kenya University examination material illustrating common introductory exam areas such as the nature and scope of political science, political ideologies, theories of state origin, gender and leadership, and human rights.

Study note: Always follow your lecturer's prescribed syllabus, terminology and required readings where they differ from this general guide.